



WRITING A WINNING BID

A Bid Prompts card deck for firms who sell to the public sector.

OXYGEN
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WRITING A WINNING BID

Win more public sector tenders with
these critical question prompts.

Getting started

HOW TO USE THESE QUESTION PROMPTS

These cards are designed to help those targeting the UK public sector prepare robust, work-winning tender bids.

Each card contains a number of high-level prompts, from understanding the buyer's decision making process to creating a service level agreement.

Using these cards in bid reviews can ensure that your bid addresses criteria such as risk management, social value, sustainability, and cybersecurity.

Through their repeated use you can increase your chances of bid success.

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UNDERSTANDING YOUR BUYER'S PRIORITIES

Key questions to consider are:

- Do you understand the buyer's strategic plan and objectives?
- Have you identified the key projects and initiatives for the buyer?
- Are you aware of any other relevant upcoming procurement events?
- Do you know how the buyer is responding to the current political and economic climate? Should this be reflected in any way in your bid?

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KNOWING THE BUYER BEHIND THE TENDER

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you mapped the organisational structure, including key stakeholders and influencers that will affect the buyer's decision-making processes?
- Do you know which budgetary processes, including any external funding, will apply to this tender?
- Do you know what the buyer's policies and current priorities are?

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IS THIS THE RIGHT OPPORTUNITY?

Key questions to consider are:

- Do you fully understand the evaluation criteria?
- Do you understand the weighting to be given to different criteria?
- Does your value proposition give you a good chance of winning?
- Have you identified all key timings?
- Given the bid timings, are you able to complete your bid in time?

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KNOWING YOUR TUPE RESPONSIBILITIES

Key questions to consider are:

- Will the contract involve the transfer of staff from the incumbent supplier? If so, Transfer of Undertakings (Protection of Employment) Regulations, aka TUPE, may apply.
- If TUPE applies, does your bid explain how you will manage the TUPE process to protect both workers rights and the continuity of service delivery?

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UNDERSTANDING SERVICE USERS' POWER

Key questions to consider are:

- Do you know the importance of service users in the contract award?
- Have you identified the types and needs of service users who will be served through the contract?
- Have you outlined how you will engage with service users?
- Can you give examples of relevant contracts where service user involvement was a key factor in delivering a successful outcome?

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PROVIDING EVIDENCE OF VALUE FOR MONEY

Key questions to consider are:

- Do you know how "value for money" will be judged by the buyer?
- Have you provided examples of how your organisation has delivered value for money in the past?
- Can you demonstrate how your bid provides value for money compared to your competitors?
- Have you outlined how you will continually review the value you deliver during the contract period?

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MANAGING YOUR SUPPLY CHAIN WELL

Key questions to consider are:

- Buyers expect strong supply chain management. Does your bid detail how you will ensure your suppliers meet the buyer's expectations?
- How you will maintain good supplier relationships?
- Can you ensure security of supply?
- Does your bid demonstrate how you will ensure supplier quality and manage underperformance?
- Is your escalation process clear?

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EVIDENCE OF YOUR DIGITAL CAPABILITIES

Key questions to consider are:

- Does your bid adequately highlight your organisation's digital infrastructure and expertise?
- Have you shown how you use technology to enhance your products or services?
- Can you demonstrate how you intend to use digital technologies to communicate with service users and key customer stakeholders?
- Do you have digital certifications?

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SHOW YOUR SOCIAL VALUE COMMITMENT

Key questions to consider are:

- Social Value is an important part of the public procurement agenda. Have you detailed your approach to social value, including policies, initiatives and philanthropic efforts?
- Does your bid highlight how your operations involve the community?
- Can you show how your organisation has positively impacted communities e.g. awards, local job hires, case studies?

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YOUR APPROACH TO SUSTAINABILITY

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you described your approach to sustainability and environmental responsibility, including any efforts to reduce your carbon footprint?
- Does your bid include evidence of compliance with environmental regulations and standards?
- Have you remembered to highlight any eco-friendly initiatives or certifications, and how you will continue to improve in this area?

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ACCESSIBILITY AND INCLUSION APPROACH

Key questions to consider are:

- Public sector buyers actively seek out partners who can demonstrate their commitment to accessibility and inclusion. Have you outlined how your solution will cater to the needs of all service users?
- Can you provide evidence of how you have successfully approached accessibility and inclusion before?
- Do you have certifications or policies to demonstrate how you value diversity and inclusiveness?

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SHOW YOUR APPROACH TO RISK MANAGEMENT

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you described your overall risk management strategy?
- Does your bid describe how your organisation identifies, evaluates, prioritises and mitigates risk?
- Is it clear which personnel have risk management responsibilities for the deliverables under the contract?
- Have you shared how you will ensure compliance with relevant laws and regulations?

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ADDRESSING ANY DATA SECURITY CONCERNS

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you outlined the controls in place to protect the buyer's data?
- Have you evidenced previous successful cybersecurity initiatives or certifications you can share?
- Can you point to anything that will show your compliance with relevant data protection regulations?
- Have you outlined your disaster recovery and business continuity plans in case of a security breach?

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IS HEALTH AND SAFETY UNDER CONTROL?

Key questions to consider are:

- Do you have all the necessary certifications and are they all up-to-date?
- Do you know and comply with all Health and Safety regulations that are relevant to this contract?
- Have you been able to demonstrate how you will ensure the safety and wellbeing of your team, as well as service users and/or stakeholders?

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ADDRESSING REQUIRED INSURANCE POLICIES

Key questions to consider are:

- Are there any required insurance policies and/or specific coverage you will need to be able to tender?
- Can you provide evidence of any relevant insurance certifications?
- Are you able to give detail on any procedures or best practices that you follow to safeguard your insurability in the future?
- Can you show how you will further mitigate risk through insurance?

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REASSURE WITH YOUR IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

Key questions to consider are:

- Does your bid detail your organisation's approach to project management and implementation?
- Buyers naturally want to minimise unnecessary risk and disruption. Does your bid set out the steps needed for a smooth transition from the current solution?
- Does your bid discuss the handover and provide the buyer with a realistic timeline and milestones?

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TRAINING YOUR TEAM FOR SUCCESS

Key questions to consider are:

- Do your staff have the necessary skills and knowledge to deliver the services under the contract?
- If not, what training can you commit to now that will allow you to comply with the tender's requirements?
- Will you need to bring on new staff to service the contract? If so, have you identified the training needed to meet the standards required?

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YOUR CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT PITCH

Key questions to consider are:

- How will the buyer's needs impact your approach to continuous improvement?
- Can you demonstrate your commitment to continuous improvement with examples of how you have implemented continuous improvement processes in the past?
- Have you outlined how you will measure and report on continuous improvement during the contract?

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SHOW HOW YOU WILL TRACK PERFORMANCE

Key questions to consider are:

- Can you propose performance metrics and KPIs to measure the success of the contract, and ensure alignment with the buyer's goals?
- Can you evidence previous successful implementation of performance metrics and KPIs in similar projects you can highlight?
- How regularly can you provide a metrics update to the customer?
- How will you meet buyer-set KPIs?

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MEETING THE SERVICE LEVEL AGREEMENT

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you fully read and understood the Service Level Agreement (SLA)?
- Are you confident that your bid can meet or exceed the requirements in the Service Level Agreement (SLA)?
- Do you know how you will manage and report on the SLA?
- Can you show how your approach to the SLA, including penalties, is aligned with the buyers needs?

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MAKE YOUR PRICING CLEAR AND CONCISE

Key questions to consider are:

- Does your bid contain a clear and transparent pricing structure?
- Does your bid pricing align with the budget allowed for the tender?
- Do you understand how your pricing will affect your bid score?
- Have you explained any pricing assumptions or exclusions?
- Does your bid contain a breakdown of relevant costs and how they relate to fair market value?

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MAKING YOUR VALUE PROPOSITION CLEAR

Key questions to consider are:

- Your bid must meet the scoring criteria, but it's also important you highlight what makes your business unique. Have you set out the unique value you can offer?
- Do you have any partnerships or associations to set your bid apart?
- Have you any proprietary processes or technology that are relevant?
- Can you offer any unique facilities or complementary services?

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SELLING THE QUALITY OF YOUR PEOPLE

Key questions to consider are:

- Every supplier believes their people are the best – but few can prove it. Can you provide evidence of the expertise and experience of your team in delivering similar contracts?
- How can you reassure the buyer that you will have adequate resources to deliver the contract?
- Have you outlined how you will manage any potential resource conflicts or constraints?

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MAKING YOUR CASE WITH CASE STUDIES

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you been able to demonstrate your success in similar projects?
- Do you have case studies or testimonials from similar customers that you can include in your bid to showcase your experience?
- Can you cite any innovative or unique solutions you have provided to similar customers in the past?
- Have you won any awards for past work that is relevant to this bid?

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CLEARLY SETTING OUT YOUR EXIT STRATEGY

Key questions to consider are:

- Most contracts eventually come to an end, and this contract is likely no exception. Have you explained how you will manage the end of the contract so that it goes smoothly?
- Have you explained how you will handle the transfer of any assets and/or the handover of any staff?
- Does your bid outline how you will handle outstanding issue resolution at the end of the contract?

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TIME TO GIVE YOUR BID A FINAL CHECK

Key questions to consider are:

- Have you addressed all mandatory questions in your bid?
- Have you evidenced against the requirements of the tender?
- Is your bid written in plain English and are your deliverables realistic?
- Have you met all aspects of the buyer's tender, including technical, commercial, environmental, legal, social value, and governance needs?

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